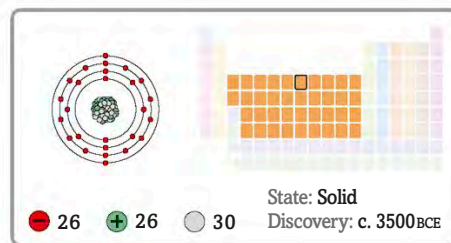


26
Fe

Iron



Forms

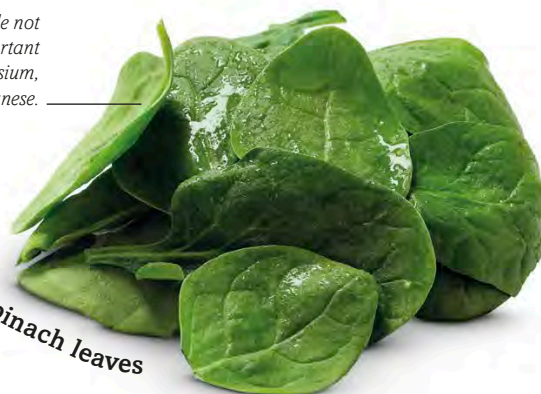


Pyrite

Cube-shaped crystal

This mineral is a compound of iron and sulfur.

Spinach leaves provide not only iron but other important elements, such as potassium, calcium, and manganese.



Spinach leaves

Pure iron is a brittle metal that can shatter easily.

Iron is the **most common metal** on our planet.



Solid lump of pure iron

Iron meteorite

Chunk of pure iron refined in a laboratory



Blood contains almost 70% of the iron in the human body.



Blood sample

Most of the iron on our planet is locked away in Earth's hot, molten core. This element is widely found in rocks worldwide, and almost 2.5 billion tonnes of iron is purified every year. Mineral ores rich in iron include **pyrite**. Other ores, including haematite, are used to extract

pure iron in a process called smelting. **Iron-rich meteorites** – chunks of rock from outer space that crash to Earth – are one of very few sources of naturally pure iron. The human body uses iron to make haemoglobin, a substance in blood that carries oxygen around our body (oxygen helps